



NIGERIAN PEOPLES AND CULTURE



# MAKERS OF NIGERIA

**ABIMBOLA OYARINU**

Ph.D History and Strategic Studies



### LEARNING OBJECTIVE

At the end of the lesson, you should be able to:

- Identify Nigerians from all walks of life, like in politics, the economy, and the creative industry.
- Examine their contributions to national development.
- Assess their inspirations for contributions.





## HERBERT MACAULAY 1864-1946

Tagged the father of Nigerian nationalism, Herbert Macaulay was one of the key figures who helped lay the foundation of modern Nigeria.

During the 1920s, when Nigeria started to witness political agitation for self-rule, Macaulay was among the first generation of Nigerian Nationalists who protested against some policies introduced by British colonial rule, including water rates, land issues, and the management of railway finances.





### HERBERT MACAULAY

It was during that time, in 1923, that he founded the Nigerian National Democratic Party (NNDP), Nigeria's first political party whose members were the first to sit in the legislative council and which held sway in Nigeria's political theatre until the late 1930s, when it joined forces with the Nigerian Youth Movement to form the National Council of Nigeria and the Cameroons (NCNC), a nationalist organisation designed to advocate for Nigeria's independence.



## OBAFEMI AWOLOWO 1909-1987

Obafemi Awolowo, who was the first premier of the western region from 1954 to 1960, was another nationalist who played an active role in the struggle for Nigeria's independence.

For some, he was Nigeria's foremost federalist and advocated for federalism as the only basis for equitable national integration.





### OBAFEMI AWOLOWO

While he led the Action Group (AG), Awolowo was at the forefront of the campaign for a federal constitution, which was introduced in the 1954 Lyttleton Constitution. As the leader of the opposition, he frequently challenged the policies of the Balewa-led government under the Northern People's Party.

Awolowo was one of the country's leading social democratic politicians who, in his agitation for self-rule, was also known to have stood for economic and social development, especially in the Western region.



## NNAMDI AZIKIWE 1904-1996

Azikiwe was a leading figure of modern Nigerian nationalism who spent the better part of his life working to end British control of Nigeria, both as a journalist and a politician.

Azikiwe served as the last governor-general of Nigeria from 1960 to 1963, as well as the country's first elected president from 1963 to 1966 during the first republic.

He joined politics in 1944 and later co-founded the National Council of Nigeria and the Cameroons (NCNC). After a successful stint as a journalist, he became active in politics in 1944.





### NNAMDI AZIKIWE

He inspired the Zikist movement, a radical revolutionary and multi-ethnic youth body which championed the Nigerian struggle against imperialism and the belief that Nigerians and indeed Africans should manage their own affairs.





## MID-LESSON QUESTION

Mention two other prominent 'Makers of Nigeria' across any field, and how their contributions have influenced the country's development and progress?



### FUNMILAYO RANSOME-KUTI 1900-1978

Funmilayo Ransome-Kuti stood against British colonial rule, demanding the rights of citizens in the pre-independence era. As a revolutionary, she was known to have used her influence to mobilise women and organise resistance against colonialism at the time, earning her the moniker "Lioness of Lisabi".

She mobilised market women for events such as picnics and festivals and, in 1953, organised a conference in Abeokuta to discuss women's welfare. The gathering gave birth to a women's group known as the Federation of Nigerian Women's Societies (FNWS), which set out to fight for women's rights against all odds.





## FUNMILAYO RANSOME-KUTI

One of the most memorable points of her life, which unfortunately resulted in her death, was on February 18, 1977, when hundreds of soldiers raided the Lagos residence of Fela Kuti, her son, who was also a known activist.

The 76-year-old Ransome-Kuti was thrown from a second-story window, during which she sustained injuries that eventually led to her death on April 13, 1978.

Cheryl Johnson-Odim described her as "the only Nigerian woman of her time to rank as such a national figure or have the international exposure and connections of Ransome-Kuti."



### FELA ANIKULAPO-KUTI 1938-1997

Nigeria's most famous musician, Fela Anikulapo-Kuti, used words as a form of protest and resistance and also as a means of reflecting on and commenting on political events. As he rose to prominence throughout the 1970s, he caused a change in the relationship between music as an art form and Nigerian socio-political discourse.

He is widely credited as the creator of Afrobeat in the early 1970s, which rapidly became the most avidly followed African style of music.





## CHINUA ACHEBE 1930-2013

One of the most acclaimed novelists of his generation, Achebe is famous for his unsentimental depictions of the social and psychological disorientation that follows the imposition of Western customs and values upon traditional African society. His first novel, *Things Fall Apart* (1958), often considered his masterpiece, is the most widely read book in modern African literature.

Achebe also openly supported the secessionist Biafra movement and even took a position as head of the Biafra Broadcasting Service at great risk to his life and career. After the civil war, he became active with the left-leaning People's Redemption Party (PRP).





### CHINUA ACHEBE

In 1983, he became the party's deputy national vice president and continued to pull discourse towards Nigeria's corrupt polity, notably in his book, "The Trouble with Nigeria".

Achebe says in the first page of the book: "The Nigerian problem is the unwillingness or inability of its leaders to rise to the responsibility and to the challenge of personal example, which are the hallmarks of true leadership."





## WOLE SOYINKA 1934- PRESENT

His achievements in literature and political activism confirm this. As a 33-year-old graduate in 1967, he was imprisoned by the Nigerian military government for 22 months for speaking out against the Nigerian civil war, and in 1994, he fled the country after the dictatorship in power charged him with treason for criticising the military junta.

In both instances, Soyinka continued to criticise the undemocratic governments of the day and call out the oppression of Nigerians. Since the return to civilian rule in 1999, Soyinka has continued to activate political discourse around the needs of the average Nigerian and the corruption of the polity.



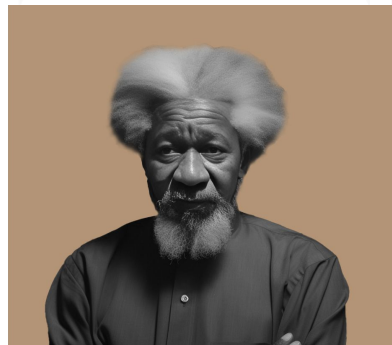




### WOLE SOYINKA

Even during his acceptance speech when receiving the Nobel Prize for Literature in 1986 (the first African to do so), he took the opportunity to focus the world's attention on the continuing injustice of white rule in South Africa and dedicated the award to the imprisoned Nelson Mandela.

For all his contributions to Nigerian society, Wole Soyinka is indeed a symbol of Nigerian resilience and a true generational impact leader.







## GANI FAWEHINMI 1938-2009

Up until he actually started practising law, all Ganiyu “Gani” Oyesola Fawehinmi wanted was to be a successful lawyer. But when he started practising in Lagos in 1965, he soon realised that he also wanted to affect the lives of everyday Nigerians and leave a legacy of impact. He did exactly that.

Often representing those who couldn't afford his services, Fawehinmi quickly became known as “the people's lawyer,” taking on a great number of pro bono cases over the course of his career.





### GANI FAWEHINMI

Fawehinmi played the role of human rights campaigner for 40 years, constantly challenging military rulers and defending their victims. His brushes with the authorities earned him frequent detentions and beatings, and on one occasion, his books were seized and his library set on fire.

He believed in media freedom, contributed avidly to newspapers, and often took on journalists' cases. The most notable of these was the still unsolved case of Dele Giwa, a magazine editor who died in a parcel bombing in 1986. Fawehinmi sought to re-open the Dele Giwa case and called on the federal attorney general to be removed for his indifference to corruption, all from his sick bed. He died in 2009 after a long battle with cancer, still as resilient as ever.



## NWANKWO KANU 1976- PRESENT

Nwankwo Kanu is one of the most celebrated Nigerian sportsmen. His contributions to both his club and country gave Nigeria positive international recognition. His stern contribution won the 1996 Olympic Gold medal for Nigeria, beating Brazil and Argentina on the road to Gold.



He won the African Footballer, the Premier League, the UEFA Champions League, the UEFA Cup, etc. in his long and fulfilling career.

He is also a UNICEF ambassador, and his foundation has helped a lot of Nigerian children who had heart complications.



### SUMMARY

This list is not exhaustive, as there are remarkable Nigerians who are achieving great feats and putting Nigeria on the global map.

Notable names like Burna Boy, Wizkid, Davido, and Rema are a few who are drawing positive attention to Nigeria through music, and they deserve a mention.



## FURTHER READING

Odularu, G. O. A. (Ed.). (2023). *Contemporary Issues, Empirics, and Policies*. Springer.

Adjei, P. O. W., & Adu-Gyamfi, S. (Eds.). (2022). *Democratic Decentralization, Local Governance and Sustainable Development*.

Muzee, H., Sunjo, T. E., & Enaifoghe, A. O. (Eds.). (2022). *Democracy and Africanness*.



## REFERENCES

Who's Who in Nigeria: A Biographical Dictionary,  
Apapa, Times Press, 1971.



# THANK YOU